



Leading ethically to shape service-oriented organizational citizenship behavior among tourism salespersons: Dual mediation paths and moderating role of service role identity

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ABSTRACT

While ethical leadership may have boundary-spanning effects on different stakeholders even beyond the organizational boundaries, the role of ethical sales leadership in promoting sales and service behavior outcomes has not been fully researched. Our research aims to unfold how and when sales managers' ethical leadership evokes service-oriented organizational citizenship behavior (OCB) among salespersons in the tourism setting. Grounded on the dataset from managers and employees working in sales departments of tour companies in Vietnam, the results reveal the role of adaptive selling and service harmonious passion as dual mediation channels for the link between ethical sales leadership and service-oriented OCB. The findings further lend credence to the moderating role that service role identity plays for the impacts of ethical sales leadership on these two mediators.

1. Introduction

In a dynamic marketplace, the salesforce not only communicates their market offerings' value to customers but also plays a proactive role in engendering customer value by serving customers to their utmost satisfaction even beyond their work roles (Lucia-Palacios et al., 2020). A valuable resource for such a role of the salesforce is sales leadership (Mertens and Recker, 2020; Schwepker Jr and Ingram, 2016). Furthermore, in the wake of recent corporate scandals in both Western and non-Western countries (Bedi et al., 2016; Hung et al., 2015) as well as sales scandals such as Wells Fargo's (Glazer and Simon, 2017), the need is underscored for sales leadership that can minimize such unethical sales behaviors as well as lead the salesforce to serve customers in an ethical and discretionary manner. McClaren's (2013) review of sales management and personal selling ethics calls for further inquiries into leadership styles in connection with ethical sales behaviors such as ethical leadership style. Leading ethically entails demonstrating normatively right behaviors via personal and relational actions and through activation of such behaviors among members by means of interaction, role modelling, orientation, and reinforcement (Brown et al., 2005).

Although much is known about ethical leadership effectiveness in organizations, it is not until recently that scholarly attention has been

devoted to its benefits in the tourism industry (Dimitriou and Schwepker Jr, 2019; Javed et al., 2017). Ethical leadership is crucial in the tourism context since tourism employees confront numerous problems including monotonous jobs, role stress, long and irregular work hours, heavy workload, and low pay (Ariza-Montes et al., 2019), and they are hence more likely to seek and anticipate fair, supportive, and caring treatments from leaders. A few tour operators such as G Adventures and TUI have adopted ethical leadership principles in their organizational philosophies (G Adventures, 2006; Šuleić et al., 2014). Ethical leader attributes (e.g., concerns for employees, empowerment, integrity, and reliability) have been identified as competencies of tourism managers and applied in leadership development programs by tourism companies (Šuleić et al., 2014).

Despite such a practical significance, with the exception of Garba et al. (2018) that investigated the nexus between ethical leadership and customer-oriented behavior, research has remained relatively quiet about benefits associated with ethical leadership in the tourism discipline beyond outcomes associated with organizations' internal facets, particularly on crucial behaviors required for the sustainable growth of tour organizations as well as the industry such as sales employees' citizenship behaviors directed toward customers (i.e., service-oriented citizenship behavior; service-oriented OCB). Service-oriented OCB is defined as a discretionary behavior in serving customers beyond

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